EU opens Pandora's negotiating box

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Presented by Amazon By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC with GREGORIO SORGI, ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH and GERARDO FORTUNA GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, remin

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, reminding you not to forget your umbrella today, especially if the strikes have you walking to work (more on that below). Let's get started.

In today's Playbook:

— What to expect from the Irish presidency's long-awaited EU budget proposal.

— Russia and China will swoop in if the EU cuts development funding, Dublin warns.

— Faces in the crowd: Neale Richmond, Romana Jerković, Elif Eralp, Thomas Byrne, Carla Tavares, Thomas Regnier, Siegfried Mure□an, Zack Polanski and more …

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Sarah and Helen discuss plague, Donald Trump's drug price war and whether the EU learned anything from Covid with health diplomat Michel Kazatchkine.

**A message from Amazon: Businesses across Europe are using the AWS Cloud to modernise essential industries. In Valmacca, Italy, xFarm uses cloud technology to help farmers make data-driven decisions, improve productivity, and support more sustainable agricultural practices—connecting farms across Europe and beyond. Hear from more AWS customers across Europe. **

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — PANDORA'S NEGOBOX: EU governments are bracing for the proposed size of the bloc's next seven-year budget to be cut by €100 billion to €200 billion compared with the plan announced in June, according to a dozen European diplomats Gregorio Sorgi and I spoke to .

Starting gun: Ireland, in its role at the helm of the presidency of the Council of the EU, will unveil its negotiating document, or "negobox," tomorrow morning (yes, a Saturday), which will set the scene for no-doubt fraught discussions between leaders at a two-day summit in Brussels next week.

“It starts with a one,” a diplomat said, tantalizing us with the number of billions to be reduced from the proposal.

In the weeds: Cuts will be light or non-existent to agriculture and regional spending, which account for almost half of the total budget, five diplomats told us. This would be a victory for 17 countries including Italy, Spain and Poland, which opposed cuts to these policies in a joint statement last week.

Firing line: Administration, the €118 billion earmarked for the EU’s institutions and staff, is the easiest target. However, larger reductions are expected from the Global Europe fund, the EU’s €200 billion pot of development aid and external relations cash, and the €410 billion European Competitiveness Fund to boost the bloc’s industrial capacity, the diplomats said.

“We are very concerned that Ireland would decide to smash funding for research and external action, which is a major issue for development, our economic interests and migration,” one diplomat said.

Your regular reminder of the fight: The bloc is split between so-called frugal countries including Germany, Austria and the Netherlands, which want several hundred billion euros slashed from the nearly €2 trillion proposal, and the “Friends of Cohesion,” a rival coalition of southern and eastern countries.

There has been “substantial progress” toward an agreement between EU member countries, Ireland’s European Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne told the European Parliament. But “we cannot satisfy everybody.” He added to Playbook the negobox was a “realistic basis” for more talks.

Any way you slice it: Stripping administration, Global Europe and competitiveness alone won’t satisfy the frugals, who want cuts across the board. They will be asking “where did they cut and did they cut enough?” said one diplomat.

How to pay for a smaller budget: The European Commission’s five proposed EU-wide taxes — known as “own resources” — are expected to make it into the negobox, the diplomats said. But Dublin might suggest tweaks to levies including a corporate tax, known as CORE, that’s particularly unpopular with European governments. The European Parliament’s proposed taxes will be left out entirely.

All of this points to a tense summit. Those talks’ chances of success “depend on the negobox,” said a diplomat. But: “Time is running out. The European Council has clearly been too slow so far,” Siegfried Mure□an, the European People’s Party’s budget negotiator, told me.

BIG AND BREAKING

LIKE A SPY MOVIE: Antoaneta Roussi has a must-click profile of the former head of Germany’s foreign intelligence service accused of profiting from state secrets.

PARTY EXIT: MEP Romana Jerković has stood down from her national party after POLITICO revealed her inner circle attended a taxpayer-funded European Parliament event in Strasbourg, Mari Eccles reports.

READY TO RULE: Alternative for Germany is softening its pledge to quit the euro — a sign that the party is seriously preparing to govern Germany , Johanna Treeck writes.

WINTER SNAP: The EU is facing a winter gas shortage that could leave the bloc scrambling to replace lost energy supplies equivalent to the power used by up to 12 million homes, reports Ben Munster.

EUROPE'S DEVELOPMENT RETREAT

DON'T PUT AID LAST: Cuts to EU development funding will leave a vacuum for Russia and China and result in more migration to Europe, Irish International Development Minister Neale Richmond told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich.

"If you cut a country's development budget, it will force people to go on the move," he said ahead of today's meeting of EU development ministers in Dublin. "If people don't have access to good health care systems, if the infrastructure is crumbling around them, they will move."

Well, that's depressing: The get-together at Dublin Castle is the first gathering of EU development ministers in almost two years. Richmond said the "dispiriting" gap reflects the extent to which humanitarian aid has slipped down the global agenda.

"Globally, we've seen development cooperation drop by over 23% in the last year, not just due to cuts from the United States, but also from many EU member states," he said, adding that Ireland and Spain were the only two to increase their development budgets.

Budget squeeze: Global Europe, the EU's main cash pot for funding countries outside the bloc, is among the areas facing a budget squeeze in Ireland's negobox. Any serious cuts there would be "crazy," the Socialists and Democrats' budget co-rapporteur Carla Tavares said.

RIP USAID: A diplomat from a country receiving EU funding — granted anonymity to avoid prejudicing future applications for the funds — compared the cuts to the Trump administration's gutting of USAID and said they will open the door for Moscow and Beijing.

Filling the void: Richmond argued that giving aid is in Europe's geostrategic interest. "The more the U.S. withdraws, the more that EU withdraws, that void is generally being filled by Russia," he said, pointing to the Kremlin's influence operations in Africa and efforts by China, Turkey and others to increase their footprint.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

EU countries will meet on Sunday to try to agree on a negotiating position on the digital omnibus … but what is that? It's a package of red-tape slashing measures for tech regulations that was proposed by the European Commission. The member countries hoped to have already found a common position so talks can start with the Commission and Parliament, but Germany is seeking tougher protections for trade secrets.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

CRUEL CLICKBAIT

GONE PHISHING AT THE BERLAYMONT: European Commission officials have been notified of the launch of a shiny new cross-institution AI assistant. The catch? The launch isn't actually a new super-helper to speed up policy work. It's a gullibility test, Gerardo Fortuna reports.

The bait: Commission officials were prompted to click a link to activate their access to the new service, touted in an email obtained by Playbook, with a warning that failure to do so could result in losing access to key AI features.

Hook, line and sinker? The email — a routine phishing exercise to see whether officials click on suspicious links or report them — was sent by the Commission's own IT department to test the computer literacy of the EU executive's 30,000-strong workforce.

If it looks too good to be true … "In which world would we have one AI for all EU institutions?" said one official, granted anonymity to speak frankly on the institution's technical competence. "When I saw it, I knew it had to be fake."

Business as usual: Regular phishing exercises are conducted for all staff, Commission spokesperson Thomas Regnier told Playbook. The tests provide "practical experience in receiving, identifying and reporting phishing emails, thus preparing them to respond effectively to real attacks."

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4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

CRMA UPDATE: Two years after it was enacted, the EU's Critical Raw Materials Act is not going to plan , Jakob Weizman reports.

BRUSSELS TRIES CHINESE AI: The EU's cybersecurity agency and in-house research center have each begun experimenting with open AI models from China , three EU officials told Sam Clark.

"NOT GREAT, NOT TERRIBLE": The Soviet Union's record of covering up disasters like Chernobyl casts a shadow over Moscow's assurances about the suspected plague outbreak in Siberia, Claudia Chiappa writes.

STEAMY TALES: In this week's Declassified column, Paul Dallison looks at what happens when politicians turn to writing bad erotic fiction .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Light rain and a gentle breeze. High of 16C.

STRIKE ALERT: STIB is warning of "significant disruption" to Brussels' public transport today, due to strikes. Thousands will march through the streets, with many tram, metro and bus lines grinding to a halt. Playbook had a look at the affected lines and it's easier to list the ones not affected — so plan accordingly. The FGTB-ABVV union called the strike in response to the Belgian government's budget cuts.

ART, DABKE AND SOME QUESTIONABLE BEDTIMES: Staying in Brussels this weekend? From wandering into strangers' living rooms to dancing until 5 a.m., Gerardo suggests a few ways to escape the EU bubble and embrace the Belgian capital's more avant-garde side.

Come on in: More than 300 artists across some 30 locations in Etterbeek are taking part in Parcours d'Artistes tomorrow and Sunday, with paintings and performances. Some are even opening their studios and homes. It's basically an open-house weekend, with better art. And it's free.

Outsiders welcome: Prefer your art a little stranger? IN.OUT.SIDER Festival takes over LaVallée on Saturday with experimental music, performances and DJs until 4 a.m. There's a free afternoon program for kids, before things get considerably less family friendly. From €10.

Two left feet? Sunday offers a gentler challenge: a free beginner-friendly Dabke dance workshop at GC De Rinck, from 5:30 p.m. to 7:30 p.m. Learn the traditional Levantine group dance. Registration required by tomorrow.

Already a dance pro? Saturday's Ritmo Infernal at Brasserie iLLeGaaL in Forest offers Colombian and Afro-Caribbean sounds, live cumbia, a dance workshop and sancocho to keep you going until 5 a.m. Or head to SIZZLEPROOF x AB Club at Ancienne Belgique for techno, hardgroove and breaks from 11 p.m. to 5 a.m. Either way: Forget Sunday brunch.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The SPD, Greens and Left Party have cleared the first hurdles in coalition talks that could put Elif Eralp in the mayor's office, much to Friedrich Merz's dismay.

Paris: Centrist presidential hopeful Edouard Philippe has promised tax breaks on overtime, new family benefits and a 50% cut in legal immigration in a bid to jump-start his campaign .

London: Green Leader Zack Polanski failed in his bid for a Westminster seat as Labour held on to Keir Starmer's former constituency.

Washington: A federal judge indicated that he's leaning toward extending a block on Donald Trump's attempt to ban three news organizations, including POLITICO, from the White House.

Ottawa: The new leader of Canada's left-leaning New Democrats says he likes politics, he just can't stand the schmoozing.

Canberra: Conservatives will gather at the CPAC Australia national conference this weekend , with dueling speeches by Opposition Leader Angus Taylor and One Nation's Pauline Hanson — and an appearance by former U.K. PM Liz Truss.

AGENDA

— EU finance ministers meet in Luxembourg for the Economic and Financial Affairs Council. Press conference at 3 p.m. Watch live .

— Informal meeting of development ministers in Dublin. Arrivals and doorsteps starting at 9 a.m. Press conference at 3 p.m. Watch live .

— European Council President António Costa visits Amsterdam, where he meets Mayor Femke Halsema, before traveling to The Hague for talks with Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten, followed by a press conference at around 5:55 p.m. Watch live .

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič co-chairs a plenary session of the China-EU Trade and Investment Consultations in Beijing and meets Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng and Commerce Minister Wang Wentao.

— French President Emmanuel Macron receives German President Frank-Walter Steinmeier for a state visit.

— International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela meets Norwegian Development Minister Åsmund Grøver Aukrust in Dublin.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen receives Hungarian Science and Technology Minister Zoltán Tanács.

— Commission Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné holds a press point on the second group of strategic projects under the Critical Raw Materials Act at 10 a.m.

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen meets Danish Business and Competitiveness Minister Martin Lidegaard and Housing Minister Jacob Mark.

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra meets Finnish Deputy Prime Minister Riikka Purra in Luxembourg.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Sven Simon; former MEPs Nessa Childers, Mike Hookem and Emma McClarkin; Bloomberg's Ashleigh Furlong; POLITICO's James Panichi; DOT Europe's Ben Brake; former U.K. Prime Minister David Cameron; Portuguese diplomat Pedro Severo de Almeida.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Katrin Langensiepen; former MEP Élisabeth Morin-Chartier; European Commission's Christine Frayne and Anca Paduraru; Vincent-Immanuel Herr, of Herr & Speer; Alexandre Adam, Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's deputy head of cabinet; OMMAX's Stefan Sambol; EEAS' Wolfram Vetter; Finnish Coreper I Ambassador Lauri Hirvonen.

Celebrating Sunday: MEPs François-Xavier Bellamy and Nicola Zingaretti; former MEPs Gilles Lebreton and Mady Delvaux; former French Interior Minister Gérald Darmanin; Prince Constantijn of the Netherlands; Anna Hill from Open Doors International; logos' Marie-Myrtille Marichal; European Parliament's María José Zepeda.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

**A message from Amazon: Founded to support the digital evolution of farming, xFarm uses the AWS Cloud to power a platform that helps farmers improve productivity while keeping sustainability at the core of their operations. By turning agricultural data into actionable insights, xFarm enables farmers to make smarter decisions in an increasingly complex environmental and economic landscape. "With the

AWS Cloud, we can connect farms around the world, transforming agriculture through innovation while keeping sustainability at the heart of everything we do," says Giovanni Causapruno of xFarm. xFarm is one of many European businesses building on the AWS Cloud to operate at scale, strengthen resilience, and support more sustainable food systems. The AWS Cloud helps xFarm extend its impact across borders—supporting farmers as they adapt to today's environmental and operational challenges. Learn more about how businesses across Europe are growing with the AWS Cloud at AWS.eu. **

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